venerable khan was imprisoned and bastinadoed at Muzaffar's command.

The governor's new deputies in Bihar were equally harsh '[in] matters of reviews and drills and of branding . . . and in their blindness [they] neglected tact and the acceptance of excuses'; and his officials, it seems, were particularly incompetent or corrupt. Baba Khan Qaqshal, the man who had quarrelled with Shahbaz Khan en route to Gujarat, complained that he had paid 70,000 rupees 'in presents, and not one hundred horsemen have had the branding effected, and the condition of the other fief-holders of this province is still worse'.[23]

'*Bulgakh-khana*' is what the Mughals called Bengal, a 'house of turbulence'. It was a land, writes Abul Fazl, where the climate 'favour[s] the base, [so that] the dust of dissension is always rising', and at this time, the eastern chiefs were already nursing deep suspicions of Akbar and grudges against his treasury. News would have come filtering in of their strange emperor wanting to read the khutba, having convulsions on a hunt, encouraging newfangled ideas in his palace, while his representatives ransacked and humiliated his chiefs. Akbar's court may have been a 'garden of concord', as Abul Fazl chirrups, but still '[b]ase minded people cast suspicions [on the emperor] and fabricated . . . disturbance'.

It wasn't just foolish or arrogant, therefore, but positively hare-brained of Muzaffar Khan to choose this moment to reduce military stipends. Worse, he did so retrospectively. The army's salaries had been raised by 200 per cent in Bengal and 150 per cent in Bihar; Muzaffar brought them down to 150 per cent and 120 per cent respectively, and began demanding money back.

It was in this tense atmosphere, rife with resentment and rumour, that a spark fell into the eastern powder keg: a Qaqshal called Roshan Beg, newly arrived in the Bulgakh-khana from Kabul – the court of Akbar's half-brother, Mirza Muhammad Hakim.

It may seem that Akbar had forgotten all about Hakim, now in his late twenties and holding fast to Kabul ever since he made his ill-advised adolescent advance on Lahore fourteen years earlier and fled at the mere thought of Akbar's approach. But Akbar was not the kind of man to forget a possible threat, no matter now remote: he kept a watchful eye on goings-on between Kabul and Hindustan. Thus, as Roshan Beg Qaqshal greeted his